

The Glorious Tantra of the Secret Teaching of Vajrapāṇi

Śrī Guhyavajrapāṇi Abhideśa Tantra Nāma · Toh 463 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་ཕགྱ་ན་རྡོ་གླིང་བ་བསྐྱ་པའི་རྒྱ།

The Glorious Tantra of the Secret Teaching of Vajrapāṇi, known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Guhyavajrapāṇi Abhideśa Tantra and in Tibetan as Dpal Phyag na rdo rje gsang ba bstan pa'i rgyud, is a tantric scripture centered on the deity Vajrapāṇi, the Lord of Secrets, and the qualities and practices required of a yogin who seeks to accomplish him. Set in the celestial palace of Akaniṣṭha and framed as a dialogue between a ḍākinī and the Blessed One, the text belongs to the genre of Buddhist tantra and addresses themes of empowerment, compassion, wisdom, and the three trainings as foundations for tantric accomplishment. It is Toh 463 in the Kangyur, where it is classified among the tantric texts, and its translation into Tibetan is attributed to Māragdra.

It was also translated by Māragdra.

In the language of India: Śrī Guhyavajrapāṇi Abhideśa Tantra Nāma. In the language of Tibet: The Glorious Tantra of the Secret Teaching of Vajrapāṇi.

Homage to the glorious Lord of Secrets.

Thus did I hear at one time. At the palace of Akananiṣṭha called Śālabhavana, the Blessed One, the Great Glorious One, was seated, surrounded by an assembly of the gods of knowledge mantras.

Then the supreme sovereign heroine (ḍākinī) spoke these words: "Blessed One, what kind of yogin is it who accomplishes the Lord of Secrets?"

The Blessed One declared:

Endowed with compassion and great wisdom,
endowed with patience and great diligence,
having received the outer, inner, and secret empowerments,
and perfectly dwelling in the three trainings,
such a one shall truly accomplish the hero.

This is the first chapter of the Tantra of the Secret Teaching, teaching the individual who is the practitioner.

Again the heroine asked: "Blessed One, what kind of place is suitable for accomplishing this hero?"

The Blessed One declared:

A solitary place, delightful and pleasing,
auspicious, swelling with splendor, holding power,
a great charnel ground, a place of fear,
the peak of one of three mountains, or a blue-grey crag,
a place resembling the appearance of a wrathful one —
such a place is auspicious for the hero's accomplishment.

This is the second chapter of the Tantra of the Secret Teaching, teaching the place of accomplishment.

Again the heroine asked: "Blessed One, what is the visualization for generating this hero?"

The Blessed One declared:

First, empty and selfless —
all phenomena of appearance and existence
are utterly pure by their essential nature.
Within such a dharmatā,
since buddha and sentient being are non-dual,
there is no meditation, no conceptual thought, yet luminous clarity —
free from all extremes, vast as space: the meaning of the Middle Way.
Such is the intrinsic nature of mind.

Yet for those sentient beings who have not realized this,
one must cultivate compassion without direction,
free from all suffering.

The cause from which all buddhas arise
is one's own mind as the syllable HŪṂ.
From the emission and gathering of the syllable HŪṂ,
the palace and the divine throne,
and from the mantra syllables of the deity,
one generates them sequentially in their proper order.

This is the third chapter of the Tantra of the Secret Teaching, teaching the visualization of generation.

Again the heroine asked: "Blessed One, what is the inconceivable visualization of this Lord of Knowledge Mantras?"

The Blessed One declared:

Having attained the visualization of generation,
one meditates at the heart on the wisdom being (jñānasattva).

At the heart of the wisdom being,
a lotus of four petals, the size of a mustard seed.

At its center, a palace of sun and moon.

Within the palace,
one meditates as an upright flame, like the tip of a candle.

Having attained concentration upon that,
one should think of nothing whatsoever.

By contemplating the inconceivable as such,
one will attain gnosis in relation to it.

Luminous, free of conceptual thought: the body of awareness —
that is what is called gnosis.

This is the fourth chapter of the Tantra of the Secret Teaching, teaching the inconceivable visualization.

Again the heroine asked: "Blessed One, what is the retinue of this Lord of Secrets?"

The Blessed One declared:

The retinue of this great hero:
the mind retinue numbers four,
the speech retinue numbers eight,
and the body retinue is established as five hundred.

This is the fifth chapter of the Tantra of the Secret Teaching, teaching the retinue.

Again the heroine asked: "Blessed One, what is the knowledge mantra of this Great Glorious One?"

The Blessed One declared:

Oṃ vajrapāṇi hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ svāhā.

Oṃ vajrakrodhā nīlaṃbaradhara vajrapāṇi hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ svāhā.

Oṃ vajrapāṇi krodha mahācaṇḍa roṣaṇa hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ svāhā.

These are the knowledge mantras offered to the four retinues.

Oṃ vajrakrodha mahākāla ya hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ cittakroci dundzaḥ. Oṃ vajrakrodha trailokyavijaya hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ. Baṃ māraya citta rbad rbad. Oṃ vajrakrodha nāgasbuśa hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ. Māraya rakta rṅubrngubs rbad. Oṃ vajrakrodha kubera hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ. Māraya ke tsoṃ tsoṃ rbad.

These are the knowledge mantras offered to the hero's retinue of gods and the eight classes of spirits.

Mahādeva māraya sod sod. Mahānāga māraya sod sod dzaḥ dzaḥ. Mahādevī māraya hana hana. Mahāmaṇi māraya gtubs gtubs. Mahāsiddha māraya tiṣṭha tiṣṭha. Mahāyakṣa māraya bhinda bhinda. Mahātridzaḥ māraya khos khos. Mahāmaṇibindha māraya nan nan. Mahāvajra hūṃ phaṭ.

These are the knowledge mantras offered to the retinue of five hundred bearing blue garments.

Māraya rudha rudha hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ.

This is the sixth chapter of the Tantra of the Secret Teaching, presenting the knowledge mantras.

Again the heroine asked: "Blessed One, should the activities of this hero be concluded and gathered by means of fire offering, or should they not?"

The Blessed One declared:

Fire offering is of three kinds:

outer, inner, and secret — three.

Each of these is taught as fourfold:

pacifying and increasing are taught,

and the fire offerings for magnetizing and for wrathful action.

This is the seventh chapter of the Tantra of the Secret Teaching, the chapter on fire offering.

When the Blessed One, the Great Glorious One, had spoken these words, the sovereign heroine, the divine assembly of the family, all felt joyful and delighted, and they praised with admiration what the Great Glorious One had taught.

The Tantra of the Secret Teaching of the Glorious Wrathful Vajrapāṇi is complete.

Translated by the Indian scholar Valacandra and the Tibetan translator Glan Chung Darma Tshulkhriṃs, who revised and established the final text.

Translator's Notes

- The opening phrase rendered as "It was also translated by Māragdra" refers to a colophon fragment naming a Tibetan translator; the name Ma grags, possibly short for a longer name, appears before the main text begins. This is a scribal note rather than part of the tantra proper.

The term rendered "supreme sovereign heroine" for dpa' mo'i dbang phyug ma is literally "the supreme sovereign of heroines," likely referring to a leading ḍākinī figure in the assembly who serves as the interlocutor throughout the text.

The phrase "Akananiṣṭha" renders 'og min, the highest pure land of the form realm, also associated in tantric contexts with the dharmakāya buddha field. The epithet "Śālabhavana" renders lchang lo can gyi pho brang, literally "the palace of the one adorned with willow trees," which may be a specific name for the heavenly palace at Akaniṣṭha; this particular designation is unusual and worth noting.

The visualization instruction "an upright flame like the tip of a candle" renders a ṣaḍ mar me'i rtse ltar, where a ṣaḍ is a Sanskrit term for a specific meditation posture marker or upright form; the comparison to a candle flame tip is the standard interpretive reading in such deity yoga contexts.

- The mantra syllables in this passage are a mixture of Sanskrit (often garbled in transmission) and apparently Tibetan imperative-exclamatory words such as rbad (a command particle), sod sod (kill, destroy), gtubs (pierce), khos (possibly a wrathful imperative). These are preserved in transliteration as they function as integral parts of the dhāraṇī-mantra, not as translatable vocabulary. The deity name Mahākāla appears in the first mantra line, confirming the wrathful context.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.